

Carne Asada Picada

Three phases: 1 marinade / butcher / freeze · 2 salsa · 3 cook · the full taco

PORTION	THAW = MARINATE	DICE	FREEZER
450 g bags	overnight, fridge	$\frac{3}{8}$–$\frac{1}{2}$" cross-grain	3+ months

PHASE 1 MARINADE FORMULA % of beef wt · per full ~24 lb (11 kg) clod — weigh yours, multiply

Beef shoulder clod diced $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ ", across grain	100%	11 kg
Granulated garlic background	0.5%	55 g
White onion rough chunks, to blend	4%	440 g
Maggi seasoning Jugo — umami backbone	2%	220 g
Neutral or olive oil	3%	330 g
Salt Diamond Crystal — with Maggi, ~1% total sodium	0.6%	66 g

BUTCHER → MARINADE → FREEZE build ahead — the freeze + thaw does the marinating

- 1 Butcher / dice:** trim the shoulder clod and cut $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " (**1–1.5 cm**) **cubes across the grain** — uniform for even searing, cross-grain for tenderness.
- 2 Blend the marinade:** everything except the beef into a blender — blend smooth (a splash of water to get it moving if needed). It scales clean and coats evenly for bulk.
- 3 Combine:** toss the diced beef in the blended marinade until every piece is coated — a large tub / bus tub for a full clod.
- 4 Portion + freeze:** into quart bags (**450 g** each), press flat, remove air, label with the date, freeze **right away** — **no separate marinate step**.

Asada Salsa

Salsa de chile de árbol y tomatillo — grandma's: boiled tomatillo, toasted árbol, garlic, cilantro. Spicy.

YIELD	ACTIVE	HEAT	KEEPS
~2 cups (480 ml)	~25 min	Spicy	4–5 days, fridge

PHASE 2

INGREDIENTS

five things — tomatillo, árbol, garlic, cilantro, salt

Tomatillos fresh, boiled — ~1 lb, store-bought fine	~450 g
Chiles de árbol toasted — the heat; SPICY, ~12–15 g	a handful
Garlic boiled with the tomatillos	3 cloves
Cilantro fresh, raw — leaves + stems	a handful
Salt Diamond Crystal — to taste	to taste

METHOD

boil · toast · blend · salt — no onion, no fry

- 1 Boil.** Simmer the tomatillos + garlic cloves in water until the tomatillos turn **olive-green and soft** (~8–10 min). Scoop out; **save a little of the cooking water**.
- 2 Toast the árbol.** Light toast on a comal / the Ooni edge — fragrant and bendy, **zero black** (old chiles tip bitter fast). Optional: bloom a few in a spoon of beef tallow to wake them.
- 3 Blend.** Boiled tomatillo + garlic, toasted árbol, a **handful of raw cilantro** (stems too), and salt — blend smooth, loosen with the cooking water to spoonable. **No straining** (árbol skin is thin), **no frying**.
- 4 Taste. SPICY is the target** — add árbol till it bites; salt to taste. Judge on a **built taco**, not the spoon (fat + tortilla mute it).

Heat = árbol, the only knob — a big handful of the old chiles now; a **pinch** of chiltepín later (3–5× hotter). Boiled tomatillo is committed; raw-vs-charred tomatillo + raw-vs-boiled garlic are the next dial-in (ask the aunts).

Cook & Build

COOK TARGETS

this stage — the griddle

Griddle surface (IR)	450–500°F	Internal pull temp	130–140°F
Char coverage	15–20%	Final texture	crusty edge, tender

PHASE 3

COOK FROM FROZEN

ripping-hot griddle — sear, don't steam

- 1 Thaw:** fridge **overnight** — it seasons as it thaws, and with **no acid there's no mush risk**, so a full thaw is fine. **Pat dry** going in for a clean sear.
- 2 Griddle:** cast iron / flat-top ripping hot (**IR 450–500°F**), light oil. **Single layer, don't crowd** — pat surfaces dry going in. Hard sear.
- 3 Chop-and-sear:** add fresh sliced white onion alongside if you like; chop with two spatulas, let it sit **30–60 sec**, toss for crispy edges.
- 4 Finish & build:** pull at **medium, 130–140°F**. Double-stacked tortillas, the seared beef, then **fresh lime, the Phase 2 salsa, raw onion + cilantro, flaky salt**. Brightness *and* heat both come on at the table.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Tough / chewy	Cut with the grain, or overcooked	Dice across the grain; pull at 130–140°F
No char	Griddle too cool or crowded	Single layer; recover to 450–500°F
Dull, no brightness	No acid in the bag (by design)	Fresh lime + salsa at the table — that's the brightness
Gray, not seared	Wet surface or crowded pan	Pat dry going in; smaller batches; hotter pan
Not spicy enough	Salsa milder than the table wants	More árbol in the salsa (Phase 2)